Can AI go conscious ?



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Video Reference

- Why AI Isn't Going to Become Conscious — Anil Seth, TED

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The Consequential Question

- For centuries, humans have fantasized about creating artificial versions of themselves — *Frankenstein* to *Ex Machina*
- As AI grows smarter, a critical question emerges: Can a robot ever truly gaze at a sunset and feel beauty or joy?
- If AI could be conscious, we would be creating new entities with their own inner lives — and the capacity to **suffer**

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Intelligence vs. Consciousness

- **Intelligence** is about **doing**: solving puzzles, navigating situations, processing information
- **Consciousness** is about **being**: the bitter tang of coffee, the warmth of a log fire
- The two go together in humans — but that doesn't make them the same thing
- Conflating them is a reflection of our own psychology, not a scientific fact

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The Projection Bias

- Humans are psychologically built to project consciousness into things that mimic us
- LLMs like GPT reflect our own language and digitised past back at us
- Seeing consciousness in AI is like seeing a face in a cloud, or Mother Teresa in a cinnamon bun
- We don't worry whether protein-folding AI is conscious — because it doesn't pull our **psychological strings**

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The "Meat Computer" Myth

- A common assumption: the brain is just a computer made of meat rather than metal
- This metaphor implies consciousness is a special algorithm that could run on any hardware
- Historically, brains have been compared to plumbing, telephone exchanges — "computer" is just the latest metaphor
- Metaphors are useful, but mistaking them for identity is a **category error**

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Mindware vs. Wetware

- In computers, software is separate from hardware — the algorithm is all that matters regardless of silicon
- In brains, you **cannot separate** what they *do* from what they *are*
- Biological brains involve neurotransmitters and electromagnetic fields that escape digital zeros and ones
- A single neuron is a beautiful biological machine — far more complex than the cartoon neurons in AI models

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Simulation is Not Reality

- A computer simulation of a hurricane does not create real wind
- A simulation of a black hole does not suck the Earth into a singularity
- Making a simulation of the brain more detailed might make it more **useful** — but not more **conscious**

> *More fidelity ≠ more experience*

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The Aliveness of Awareness

- Consciousness is intimately connected to our nature as **living creatures**
- Unlike abstract computation, life is about materiality and the constant regeneration of conditions for existence
- Every experience carries a "tinge of aliveness" linked to survival
- It is **life**, not computation, that breathes fire into experience

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The Danger of "Conscious-Seeming" AI

- Granting rights to AI based on the *illusion* of consciousness could eliminate our ability to regulate or shut it down
- Believing an AI "feels" for us makes us psychologically vulnerable — and more likely to follow bad advice
- Treating the mind as computation "floating free from biology" **diminishes** what it means to be a living, breathing human

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Conclusion: Nature over Silicon

- AI may win the prize for intelligence — but consciousness remains ours to celebrate and share with other **living creatures**
- See ourselves as part of nature: consciousness is tied to living flesh and blood, not the "dead sand" of silicon
- By overestimating machines, we **underestimate ourselves**

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References

Topic	Source
Anil Seth's TED Talk	Why AI Isn't Going to Become Conscious (YouTube)
Anil Seth — Being You	Anil Seth's book on consciousness (Penguin)
Integrated Information Theory	IIT Overview — scholarpedia.org
Global Workspace Theory	GWT — scholarpedia.org
Embodied Cognition	Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy

> *This space evolves fast — verify Seth's latest positions at anilseth.com*

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Thank You

> *"By overestimating machines, we underestimate ourselves."*
> *— Anil Seth*

Questions & Discussion

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